racing to the boundary. After that the balls consistently hit the middle of my bat and the run rate didn't drop for the entire innings.

I had some good partnerships, first with Dinesh Karthik, then with Yusuf Pathan and finally with MS Dhoni, and they all batted well to take the pressure off me. It was only after I had passed 175 that I started to think about a double hundred. I had lost a bit of strength by then and, unable to play big shots, switched to finding the gaps and running hard. I was still running even when I was in the 190s, while Dhoni was pounding the bowling at the other end.

The moment finally arrived in the fiftieth over of our innings, when I steered the ball behind point for a single, becoming the first in the history of cricket to score an ODI double century. I was particularly glad I had been able to achieve the landmark in front of a home crowd. The team total had reached 400 and the sensation could not have been any better. In the changing room, Sehwag said to me, '*Aakhir aapne 200 bana hi diya!*' (So you finally did score the ODI double ton!)

The job, however, was only half done and we knew South Africa had successfully chased 434 in 2006 – against Australia, no less – so it wasn't a time to relax. History was not repeated in Gwalior, though, and in the end we managed to win the match convincingly by a 153-run margin.

Back in the hotel, I was feeling really tired but, because of all the excitement, was unable to sleep. Lying awake in bed, I decided to check my phone and found that it was flooded with messages congratulating me and I spent two hours responding to them, a task that eventually took me two days to complete. I was up early the next morning, too, but it didn't really matter, as I was heading home for a much-needed break after one of my best ever seasons in international cricket.

I have to admit that there was another reason I could not sleep in Gwalior. The hotel authorities had very kindly given both Dhoni and me a suite each and these were located at a fair distance from the rooms of the rest of the team. My suite was enormous and even had a private swimming pool. The bathroom was gigantic and was separated from the main living room by a glass door. Outside there were huge trees and at night, with the silk curtains fluttering in the breeze, I didn't find it the most comfortable room to sleep in. It was pitch dark outside and the size of the room, together with the unfamiliar sights and sounds around, made me seriously uneasy and I had to keep the bathroom lights on all night!